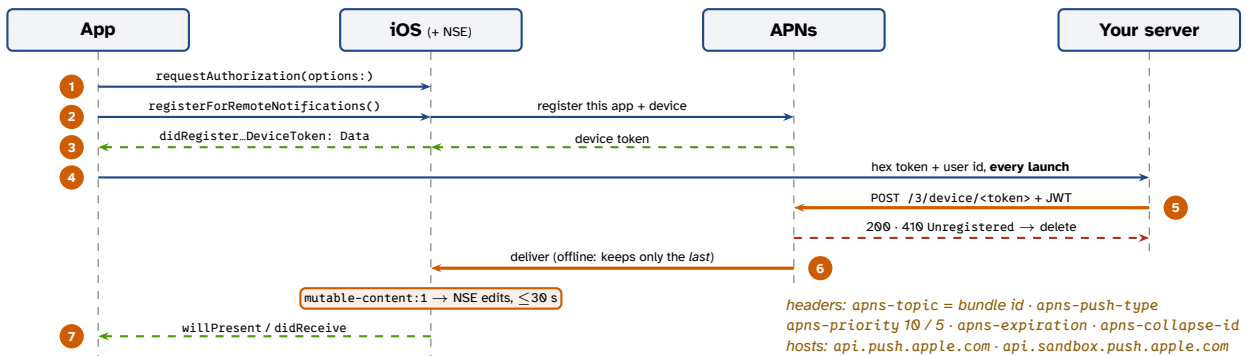


In one line: Your **server** never talks to the phone: it POSTs JSON over HTTP/2 to **APNs**, addressed by a **device token** (one app install on one device, one environment) and authenticated by *your* key. The app only asks permission, obtains and uploads the token, and reacts to delivery.



How it works

- **Token auth (.p8)**, preferred: one key for *all* your apps and both environments, never expires. The server signs a **JWT** (ES256; kid = key id, iss = team id, iat), reuses it and refreshes every 20–60 min. **Certificate (.p12)**: one per app, expires yearly.
- **Authorization** (UNUserNotificationCenter): `.alert` `.sound` `.badge` `.provisional` (iOS 12): no prompt, lands *quietly* in Notification Center, user decides later. `.criticalAlert`: ignores mute/Focus, needs an **Apple-approved entitlement**. **Time-sensitive** is an *interruption level* (passive · active · time-sensitive · critical, iOS 15) set in the payload + capability; it breaks through Focus. Check with `getNotificationSettings`.
- **Alert** push: push-type alert, priority 10. **Background (silent)**: only "content-available":1, push-type background, **priority 5**, needs the remote-notification background mode. The app wakes in `didReceiveRemoteNotification(...)` for ~30 s and must call its `fetchCompletionHandler`.
- **Service Extension** (NSE): separate process, runs only for a *visible* alert with "mutable-content":1; ~30 s in `didReceive(_ :withContentHandler:)` to decrypt, rewrite or attach media (UNNotificationAttachment). `serviceExtensionTimeWillExpire()` ships the best attempt. **Content Extension**: custom expanded UI, picked by `UNNotificationExtensionCategory`.
- **Categories**: register `UNNotificationCategory` + `UNNotificationAction` (`.foreground`, `.destructive`, text input) at launch. Payload "category" picks one; the tap arrives as `response.actionIdentifier`.

Example

```
// didFinishLaunching: set the delegate BEFORE it returns
let c = UNUserNotificationCenter.current(); c.delegate = self
c.requestAuthorization(options: [.alert, .sound]) { _, _ in }
app.registerForRemoteNotifications() // token even if denied
func application(_ a: UIApplication,
  didRegisterForRemoteNotificationsWithDeviceToken t: Data) {
  api.upload(t.map { String(format: "%02x", $0) }.joined()) }
func userNotificationCenter(_ c: UNUserNotificationCenter,
  willPresent n: UNNotification) async
-> UNNotificationPresentationOptions { [.banner, .sound] }
func userNotificationCenter(_ c: UNUserNotificationCenter,
  didReceive r: UNNotificationResponse) async {
  router.open(r.notification.request.content.userInfo) }
```

Payload (≤ 4 KB; VoIP 5 KB)

```
{ "aps": { "alert": { "title": "Door", "body": "Opened" },
  "sound": "default", "badge": 3, "category": "DOOR",
  "mutable-content": 1, "interruption-level": "time-sensitive",
  "route": "/door/7" } // own keys beside "aps"
{ "aps": { "content-available": 1 } } // silent
```

Test: `xcrun simctl push booted <bundle-id> x.apns`, or drag a .apns file onto the Simulator; on a device, Apple's Push Notifications Console or `curl --http2`.

Traps

- ! Device token ≠ .p8 key: the token addresses the install, the key authenticates the server.
- ! Works from Xcode, fails in TestFlight: Xcode builds use the **sandbox** host, TestFlight/App Store use **production**. Tokens differ, so you get `BadDeviceToken`.
- ! Silent pushes are **best-effort**: throttled (a few per hour), coalesced, delayed in Low Power Mode, and **never** delivered to an app the user force-quit.
- ! NSE "never runs": no mutable-content, no visible alert, or it crashed on its tight memory limit (the original is shown).
- ! Foreground: nothing shows unless `willPresent` returns options.
- ! The token can **change** (restore, reinstall, new device). Re-register every launch. `token.description` is not the hex string.
- ! Permission is only for *alerts*. The token and silent pushes work without it.

APNs answers

200	accepted	—
400	bad request (BadDeviceToken, BadTopic...)	fix, do not retry
403	ExpiredProviderToken, InvalidProviderToken	new JWT
410	Unregistered — token no longer valid	delete the token
413	payload too large	shrink
429	too many requests (same token)	back off
500 · 503	APNs error · unavailable	retry later

Remember

Ask · Register · Upload · Send · Deliver. The **key** names the sender; the **token** names the phone.